HANDOUT · FAITH: 101 BIBLE STUDY

METHODISM: 101

SESSION 1: HISTORY & FOUNDATIONS

GRACE COMMUNITY CHURCH

WHEN	**Wednesday, October 21, 2026 · 7:00 PM ET**
ZOOM	**Meeting ID 880 2297 9559 · Passcode 19061906**
ALSO	Live on Facebook · all are welcome
TEACHER	Rev. Dr. Arian B. Harris

SCAN TO JOIN

Where did we come from?

The word “Methodist” started as an insult. In 1729, Oxford students mocked a small group led by Charles and John Wesley for their strict “method” of prayer, Bible study, Communion and serving the poor. The name stuck.

Methodism began as a **renewal movement inside the Church of England**. In 1738, at a meeting on Aldersgate Street in London, John Wesley felt his heart “strangely warmed” and knew he trusted Christ alone. A year later he was preaching in fields to coal miners and working families.

In America, Black Methodists were part of the movement from the start. When racism pushed them to the back of the church, they built their own: the **AME** (1816), the **AME Zion** (1821) and the **CME** (1870). Grace Community Church is part of the **Christian Methodist Episcopal Church**.

Walk the history. Mother Bethel AME Church, founded by Richard Allen, still stands at 419 South 6th Street in Philadelphia, a short walk from where Grace worships.

METHODISM IN TEN DATES

- **1729** The “Holy Club” meets at Oxford
- **1738** Aldersgate: Wesley’s heart “strangely warmed”
- **1739** Field preaching begins
- **1784** Methodist Episcopal Church founded in Baltimore
- **1816** AME Church founded in Philadelphia
- **1821** AME Zion Church organized in New York
- **1844** Methodism splits North and South over slavery
- **1870** CME Church organized in Jackson, Tennessee
- **1939** Segregated “Central Jurisdiction” created
- **1968** United Methodist Church formed; Central Jurisdiction ends

WHAT METHODISTS BELIEVE

THREE KINDS OF GRACE

Prevenient · grace that goes before. God loves us first and draws us to respond. **1 John 4:19**

Justifying · grace that pardons. Forgiveness received by faith in Christ, as a gift. **Ephesians 2:8–9**

Sanctifying · grace that transforms. The Spirit growing us toward perfect love. **2 Corinthians 5:17**

THE WESLEYAN QUADRILATERAL

Four sources for thinking through hard questions. **Scripture comes first**; the other three help us understand and live it.

1 Scripture 2 Tim 3:16–17
2 Tradition 2 Thess 2:15
3 Reason Isaiah 1:18
4 Experience Romans 8:16

THIS WEEK: THE THREE SIMPLE RULES

Wesley gave every Methodist society the same **General Rules** (1743). Pick one specific action for each, then check off each day you practice it.

RULE	MY ACTION THIS WEEK	TH	F	SA	SU	M	TU	W
Do no harm Romans 12:9								
Do good Galatians 6:10 · Micah 6:8								
Stay in love with God John 15:5								

Wesley's wording for the third rule is "attending upon all the ordinances of God": prayer, Scripture, Communion, worship and fasting. Bishop Rueben Job summed it up as "stay in love with God."

THE FOUR METHODIST FAMILIES IN THIS LESSON

CHURCH	FOUNDED	REMEMBER
African Methodist Episcopal (AME)	1816 · Philadelphia	Richard Allen; the walkout from St. George's; first independent Black denomination
AME Zion	1821 · New York	James Varick; "the Freedom Church"; Tubman, Douglass, Truth
Christian Methodist Episcopal (CME)	1870 · Jackson, TN	Our church family; Bishops Miles and Vanderhorst; Lane, Miles, Paine and Texas colleges
United Methodist (UMC)	1968 · Dallas	Ended the segregated Central Jurisdiction (1939–1968)

Pray this week: God who loved us first, warm our hearts again. Teach us to do no harm, to do good, and to stay in love with you. Amen.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Use these in class, in a small group or on your own this week; the letters match the slides.

A

OPENING

What's one thing you were taught about the church you grew up in — or one thing you've always wondered about Methodists?

B

PART 1

Wesley's friends were mocked for being so "methodical." If someone watched your week, what spiritual habits would they notice?

"Train yourself to be godly." **1 Timothy 4:7 (NIV)**

C

PART 1

Have you had an "Aldersgate moment," when your heart was "strangely warmed"? Or has your faith warmed slowly over time?

"Were not our hearts burning within us while he talked with us on the road and opened the Scriptures to us?" **Luke 24:32 (NIV)**

D

PART 1

Wesley said there is "no holiness but social holiness." Who helps you grow in faith — and whom are you helping grow?

"Let us consider how we may spur one another on toward love and good deeds." **Hebrews 10:24 (NIV)**

E

PART 2

Richard Allen and Absalom Jones were pulled up off their knees while praying. What does that moment say about how the church has treated people — and how should it treat them?

"There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free... for you are all one in Christ Jesus." **Galatians 3:28 (NIV)**

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (continued)

F

PART 2

Allen walked out and built something new. Others stayed and worked for change from inside. When is leaving the right response, and when is staying?

G

PART 2

Grace is part of the CME Church, founded by formerly enslaved people who wanted to govern their own church. What does it mean to you to belong to this story?

"You also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house." **1 Peter 2:5 (NIV)**

H

PART 3

Which do you most need right now: grace that finds you (prevenient), grace that forgives you (justifying), or grace that grows you (sanctifying)?

I

PART 3

Which of the three simple rules — do no harm, do good, stay in love with God — is hardest for you right now? What would practicing it look like this week?

"He has shown you, O mortal, what is good." **Micah 6:8 (NIV)**

J

PART 3

Try the Quadrilateral: should I forgive someone who hasn't apologized? What do Scripture, tradition, reason and experience each add?

"Lord, how many times shall I forgive…? Up to seven times? Jesus answered, 'I tell you, not seven times, but seventy-seven times.'" **Matthew 18:21–22 (NIV)**